THE ARCHITECT'S FIELD NOTES

SOLUTION ARCHITECTURE PRACTICE GUIDE / 06 OF 06

Architecture Decision Field Guide

FRAME THE CHOICE. TEST THE RISKS. RECORD THE REASONING.

A practical reference for clear, evidence-based design decisions.

PREPARED FOR SENIOR SOLUTION ARCHITECTS

READ · REFLECT · PRACTICE

06

YOUR STUDY COMPANION

Decision quality at senior level

Purpose: Turn a complicated technical choice into a transparent decision that can withstand business and engineering review.

> **Note:** The examples below are illustrative. Replace them with verified details from your own work.

NAVIGATION

Inside this guide

01 1. Frame the problem

02 2. Evaluate trade-offs

03 3. Practice worksheet

CHAPTER

1. Frame the problem

A strong design decision starts with an **observable business need**, not a preferred technology. Name what must be true after the change.

Questions to answer

- Which user journey is affected?
- What would happen if no action were taken?
- Who is accountable for risk acceptance?

Dimension	Useful evidence	Warning sign
Problem	Customer impact and time constraint	Solution described before problem
Risk	Failure mode, severity, reversibility	No rollback owner
Ownership	Named decision maker and reviewers	Everyone “agreed” but nobody decided

CHAPTER

2. Evaluate trade-offs

Compare feasible choices consistently. Include the cost of **doing nothing** when that is a realistic option.

> **Example:** A team compares a full rewrite with an incremental migration. A bounded pilot may reduce uncertainty before committing the organization to a larger operating model.

Criterion	Keep current	Incremental	Full rewrite
Cost	Low upfront	Moderate	High
Delivery risk	Existing limits	Managed change	Broad change
Reversibility	High	Often higher	Often lower

A simple decision sequence

```
Define problem -> Compare options -> Test risks -> Decide -> Review results
```

CHAPTER

3. Practice worksheet

Complete this before a review meeting.

- ☐ Business objective and required outcome are clear.
- ☐ At least two realistic options have been compared.
- ☐ Security, reliability, and cost constraints are explicit.
- ☐ Rollout and rollback responsibilities are assigned.
- ☐ Success measures and review dates are recorded.

Decision: _____

Why alternatives lost: _____

Evidence that would change my recommendation: _____